These Shining Lives

By Melanie Marnich

DR. DALITSCH: (Pg 46) . . . your fractured jaw resulting from a tooth extraction and the subsequent infection in the tooth's socket, in addition to anemia . . .

CATHERINE: (Pg 9) This isn't a fairy tale . . .

DR. DALITSCH: (Pg 46) . . . the severe pain in your legs, the hard ridge that has formed along the underside of your jaw . . . is a direct result of . . .

CATHERINE: (Pg 9) It's not a tragedy . . .

DR. DALITSCH: (Pg 47) Did they warn you? Did they protect you?

CATHERINE: (Pg 9) It's something else . . . **(Pg 10)** I'm Catherine Donohue. I live in Ottawa, Illinois. I have two children [and] a husband that I love . . . **(Pg 11)** And we started like this.

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(Catherine and Tom at home; she's getting ready for her first day of work)

TOM: (Pg 11-12) Well, aren't you the prettiest thing?

CATHERINE: Be honest. How do I look? *(Strikes a pose)* Do I look like a girl worth 8 cents a watch? Who knows, maybe I'll make more than you someday. **(Pg 13)** I want to know what it feels like to make eight dollars a week. I want to know. Just once. I want to be that person. For a while. *(she struggles to fix the collar of her dress).* Tell me I can do this. Tell me I'll be good enough.

TOM: You can do it. But you won't be good enough. You'll be great.

INTRODUCTION

It was the early 1920s and one of the most sought-after jobs for young women in America involved something exciting and brand new: Radium. Sparkling, glowing, and beautiful, radium was also, according to the company, completely harmless. It would make watch faces glow in the dark. And so, an excited Catherine Donahue found her dream job at age 19 and was hired by the Radium Dial Company. It was a marvelous. . . until it wasn't.

Throughout American history, women have fought for better wages, equal rights, and safer working conditions. The Radium girls of the 1920s brought about the first legal case in which an

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employer was held responsible for the health of its employees. In the words of author Audre Lorde . . . [This is] "for those women who do not speak, for those who do not have a voice because we are taught to respect fear more than ourselves. We've been taught that silence would save us, but it won't."

Based on true events, this is These Shining Lives by Melanie Marnich

(Catherine's 1st day of work at the Radium Dial Company)

MR. REED: **(Pg 14-16)** Morning, girls. I'd like you to meet Catherine Donohue. *(as he ushers Catherine to her work station, he addresses another worker)* Charlotte? Painting the dials . . . how it's done.

CHARLOTTE: *(demonstrating)* Alright. It's easy. See? You take your little brush here, twirl it between your lips to make a point, then dip it into the powder here. Paying attention?

CATHERINE: *(mimicking Charlotte's actions)* Point . . . dip . . . and then you paint. Like this. *(She paints a number, shows Mr. Reed and puts the brush back in between her lips)* Why does it shine*? (Reacts to the taste)* It tastes awful. Is it okay? Getting this stuff in our mouths.

MR. REED: It's more than okay. [Radium] is ***medicinal***. **(Pg 17-18)** Think you can do it?

CATHERINE: Oh, I can do it. I'm sure!

CHARLOTTE: She'll be great, Mr. Reed. *(Mr. Reed exits)*

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CATHERINE: **(Pg 18)** *(speaks to the audience)* And I was. My twos swooped and dipped. My fives were flawless. And my twelves? *(gestures for extraordinary) (Beat)* I walked home that night in the dark. Ten years ago, a girl like me couldn't even vote, let alone make this kind of money. But now? *(enters the apartment and removes her coat to greet Tom, who is in the kitchen making dinner)* **(Pg 23)** You beat me home.

TOM: **(Pg 18)** Your hair! *(Catherine touches her hair)* It's shining. Your dress *(She touches her dress)* Your hands, your eyelashes, your mouth. You glow.

CATHERINE: It's the dust. From the paint . . . for the watches.

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TOM: **(Pg 23-24)** *(Pre-occupied with getting dinner on the table)* Your mom just left. The kids didn't take their nap, so they're monsters. Hungry monsters. *(He sets the table haphazardly)* Dinner's not going to be good . . . I didn't really know how to. . .

CATHERINE: *(Pulling a small box out of her handbag)* A little something. To make up for it.

TOM: *(Takes the box)* For me? Don't think you can just bribe me with gifts. I'm not that kind of girl. *(Opens the box and is wow'd by the gift)* Wait. Yeah, I am. *(Takes a pocket watch from the box and opens it)* Wow. You just bought me off with a pocket watch.

CATHERINE: *(Proudly)* I painted it. The numbers.

TOM: It's . . . perfect!

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CATHERINE: **(Pg 32-33)** *(to audience)* When I started, I thought it would only be for a while . . . Six years. *(Beat)* And like that, time passes. *(Long beat)* Before we noticed . . .

VOICE OVER: 218,723 watches later . . .

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Tom and Catherine's apartment. Catherine is in the bathroom, washing the radium dust from her hands and arms. She is in obvious pain as Tom enters

TOM: **(Pg 33-35)** Katie? I'm home. Helluva day. I drop my lunch off the twenty-second story. I could eat a horse. *(Tom enters the bathroom and clicks on the light, Catherine responds negatively, but Tom doesn't notice)* How was work? How many watches you paint today? *(He pats her on the check, again Catherine responds in pain, but Tom doesn't notice)*

CATHERINE: *(without any energy to her voice)* One seventy-five.

TOM: *(continuing in his happy-go-lucky tone)* How are the kids? You hungry? You want me to start dinner? You look tired, no offence.

CATHERINE: Tom? Look at me. You see anything different?

TOM: Just my beautiful Katie

CATHERINE: Turn off the light. *(he does so and she holds up her hands, showing her palms, then returns to the sink, washing furiously to try to remove the glow)*

TOM: It's just the dust. Like always. It'll wear off. It's fine.

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CATHERINE: But it's not just on my skin anymore. It's in my skin. Tom, it's in my body. I ache, Tom. My bones. My legs, my back.

TOM: *(refusing to see or hear)* Maybe this job's getting too hard for you. Maybe you're just tired like any working stiff.

CATHERINE: I'm not some little doll, Tom! It's not too hard for me. There's something wrong and I don't know what it is!

TOM: *(blows her off)* Your hands are dirty! So what? *(starts to walk away)*

CATHERINE: Don't you dare walk away from me!

TOM: *(losing his temper)* Listen, I'm tired too!. If this job's getting to you, don't come home and take it out on me, okay?! Every day I'm up there doing the high-wire act, worried that I won't see you and kids again just because I moved an inch in the wrong direction. I told you the day you started that work is work! So we ache! So we're tired! That's what you signed up for, Katie! Remember, you wanted this job. *(a beat of quiet)*

CATHERINE: I'm telling you. *(She experiences a sudden shooting pain in her arm and cries out loud)* There's something wrong with me. And I. Am. Scared.

TOM: **(Pg 39-40)** Maybe it's the cold, the damp.

CATHERINE: *(Still doubled over in obvious pain)* You know what would be great? If you'd actually believe me instead of making excuses. There's something wrong. It's not the weather. I'm not working too hard. God, I'm so tired.

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Mr. Reed's office at Radium Dial

MR. REED: **(Pg 44-45)** Ah, Mrs. Donohue. Come in, come in.

CATHERINE: You wanted to see me?

MR. REED: You're missing too much work, Mrs. Donohue . . . I have to let you go.

CATHERINE: What? No! Only a few days. Not that many. No more, I promise, no more. Just let me –

MR. REED: *(cutting her off)* This is a good place for girls. For healthy girls. I'm sorry.

CATHERINE: You're really firing me? For being sick?

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MR. REED: I remember the day you started, Katie. You fit right in. And you didn't rock the boat. I suggest you don't start now. I'm sorry you got sick. I'm sorry I have to let you go. It's my job. It's business, you know.

CATHERINE: No, it's not. It's a crime!

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CATHERINE: **(Pg 42)** My bones [were] breaking . . . I couldn't lift my little girl. I could barely cross the room. **(Pg 46-47)** No doctors in our town would see us. So we had to go to the city. *(Scene shifts to the doctor's office)*

DR. DALITSCH: Catherine . . . the fainting spells and destruction of your teeth [is] connected to the malignancy of your hip and necrosis of your jaw (Sees that she doesn't understand this word) Necrosis means . . . localized death of living tissue. To the best of my knowledge this is a direct result of radium poisoning. *(Catherine breaks down into tears)*

CATHERINE: *(pulling herself together)* Tell me . . . is Radium poisoning . . .

DR. DALITSCH: Terminal.

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CATHERINE: **(Pg 50)** *(alone on stage. The sound of a ticking watch in the background. As she speaks to the audience, she has more and more trouble moving her jaw, we see her physically deteriorate in pain)* This is the sound of a mother's heart breaking. *(Long pause)* This is the sound of her falling apart. *(Long pause)* This is the sound of time *(beat)* running out. *(Long pause)* I am going to die. *(beat)* **(Pg 62)** I'm not afraid of death. Really, I'm not. *(Long pause)* I'm just afraid of how I'll get there. . . *(Long pause)*

(to audience) **(Pg 52-53)** Women like me don't stir up trouble. We play nice and do what we're told. *(With strong conviction)* [But] a big part of me wonders what it would feel like to hire the best lawyer I could find and go get / those sons of . . . [So we did] **(Pg 56-57)** *(to audience)* Our case went to court. Our story went to press. And the press went to town. *(through each of the reporter's statements, the audience can see Catherine wither away)*

REPORTER 1: A travesty is unfolding just outside of Chicago, where several disgruntled women are accusing a beloved company of foul play . . .

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REPORTER 2: . . . allege that Radium Dial knowingly compromised their health, safety and lives.

REPORTER 1: . . . fired for poor performance.

REPORTER 2: . . . Radium Dial is known for paying generous wages to unskilled workers.

REPORTER 1: . . . . in spite of community pressure to step aside.

REPORTER 2: . . . grasping for a payday.

CATHERINE: **(Pg 65)** I won my case six times. The Radium Dial Company appealed six times. After losing all six, the company appealed to the United States Supreme Court . . .

REPORTER 1: **(Pg 62)** Mrs. Donohue came to the hearing today supported by her husband. Once healthy and alert, she weighted only 71 pounds and could hardly stand alone. . . .

TOM: *(to audience)* **(Pg 65)** She died 21 days later – *[NOTE: This first line is spoken by one of Catherine's co-workers (Pearl) in the original script – could be presented as a voice over before Tom speaks] (He takes out the pocket watch Catherine gave him, winds it slowly, looks at it for a moment, then speaks)* **(Pg 64)** Do you know they pulled bones out of her body while she was still alive . . . Lifted them right out. *(He starts to cry)* Could you tell me what I'm going to do with all this goddamn time? *(He caresses the watch and puts it back in his pocket.)*

CATHERINE: *(we hear the ticking of a clock, the ticking becomes a heartbeat . . then it stops. Silence, then Catherine speaks)* **(Pg 10)** They say you see a light But you don't. You see your life flash before your eyes. You see your story. Beginning . .

TOM: **(Pg 11-12)** Well, aren't you the prettiest thing?

CATHERINE: **(Pg 10)** and middle . . .

TOM: **(Pg 35)** *(angry)* I told you the day you started that work is work! So we ache! So we're tired! That's what you signed up for, Katie! Remember, you wanted this job.

CATHERINE: **(Pg 10)** And the end . . .

TOM: **(Pg 50)** *(Taking her hand, he speaks emotionally)* No one on earth can hold a candle to you . . . No one in heaven will come close.

CATHERINE: **(Pg 66- 67)** And time stood still for just a minute, just for us . . . and we were *(beat)* shining.

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AWARD HISTORY

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